An Engineer's Guide to Microsoft Word

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Written by

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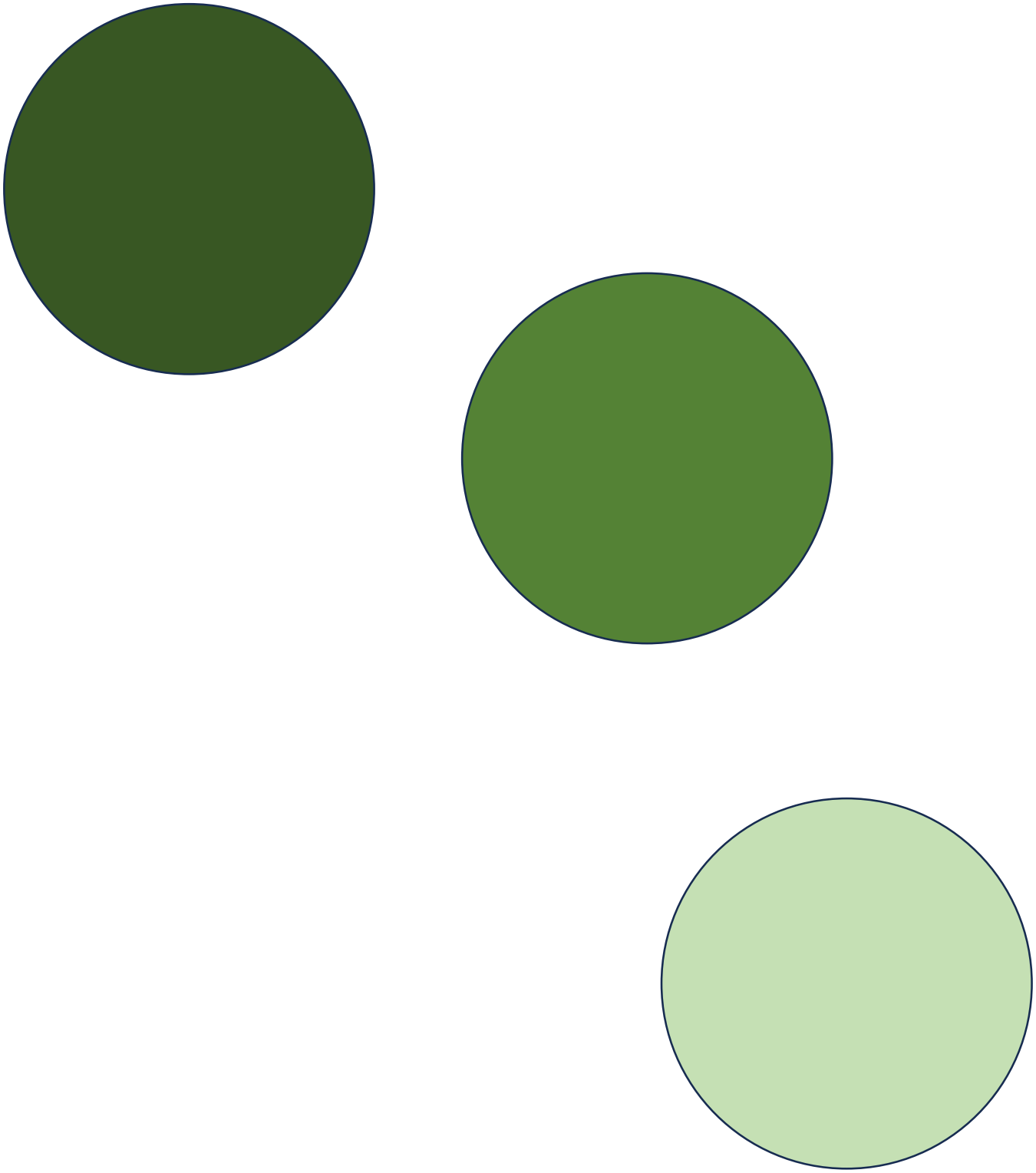


Introduction

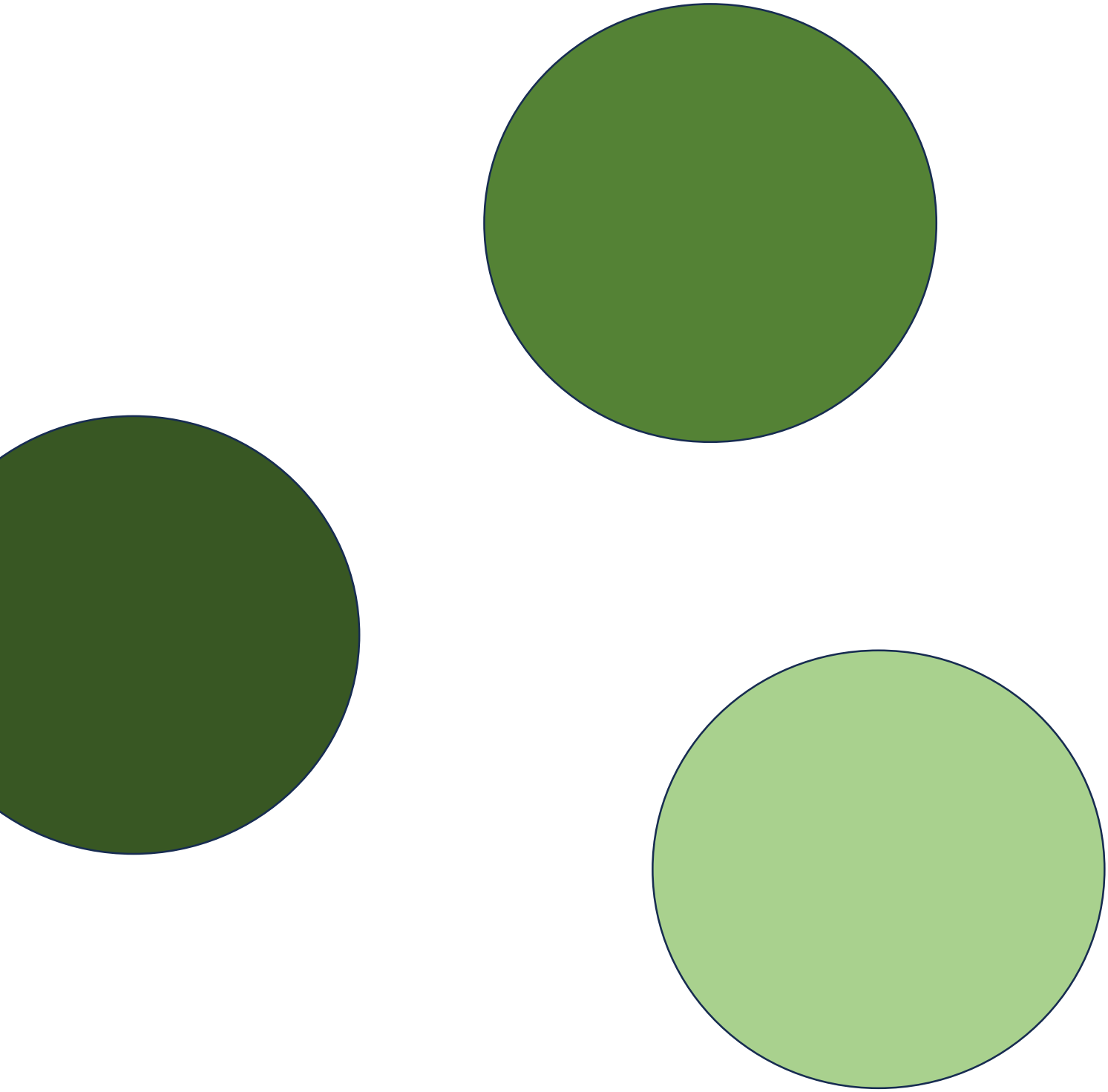
Writing lab reports can be stressful, especially when you do not fully understand the software needed to write it. *An Engineers Guide to Microsoft Word* is here to help bridge that language barrier for you.

Written and intended for use with Windows OS systems, this Microsoft Word Manual is intended for Engineering students with little to no understanding of the functions in Word. Each module focuses on its own subject, with no need for flipping between chapters to understand everything.

This manual covers the basics of Word, like how to change text size, position an image, as well as more unique features such as adding captions, and importing an excel spreadsheet. No matter where you are in your Word learning journey, this manual can help you use Words features in an easy and understandable way to make your report writing as smooth as possible.

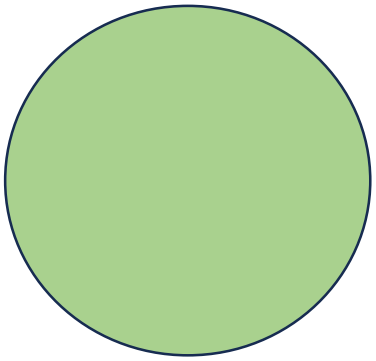
Dedication

This manual is dedicated to Engineering Majors who have long reports to write. May this manual find you in your time of need.



Chapter 1:

Getting Started



Changing Your Text Size, Color, and Font

Using different text sizes, colors, and fonts can make your document appear clean and appealing to read.

Changing Text Size

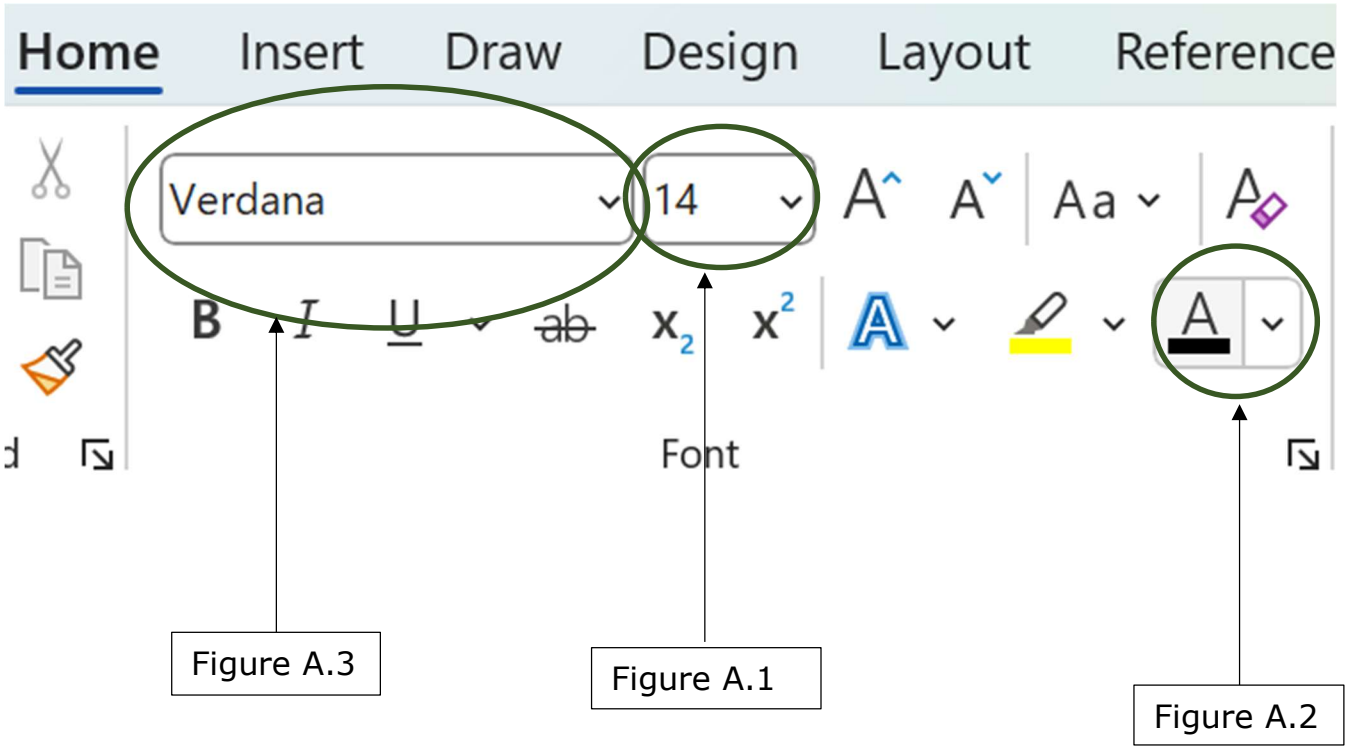
1. Click and drag to select the words that you want to change the size of.
2. Click the **Font Size** (Figure A.1) dropdown menu on the **Home** tab in the **Font** group of the Ribbon.
3. Select font size or type font size of your choice.

Changing Text Color

1. Click and drag to select the words that you want to change the color of.
2. Click the **Font Color** (Figure A.2) dropdown menu on the **Home** tab in the **Font** group on the Ribbon.
3. Select the color of your choice.

Changing Text Font

1. Click and drag to select the words that you want to change the font of.
2. Click the **Font** (Figure A.3) dropdown menu on the **Home** tab in the **Font** group of the Ribbon.
3. Select the font of your choice.



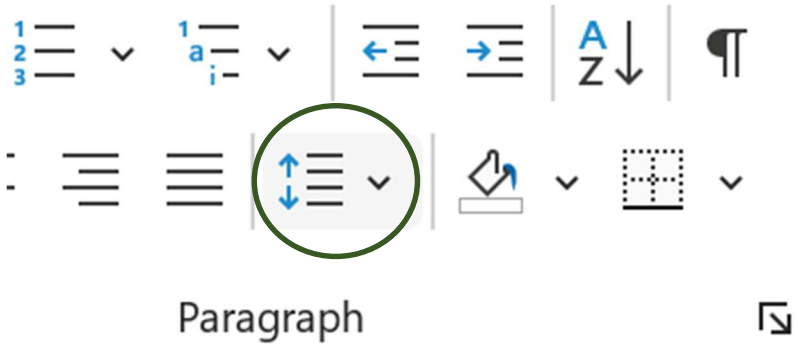
Tip: You can also use the Mini toolbar that appears automatically when you select the words.

Inserting Line Spacing

Use different line spacing to make your certain informational aspects of your document stand out.

---

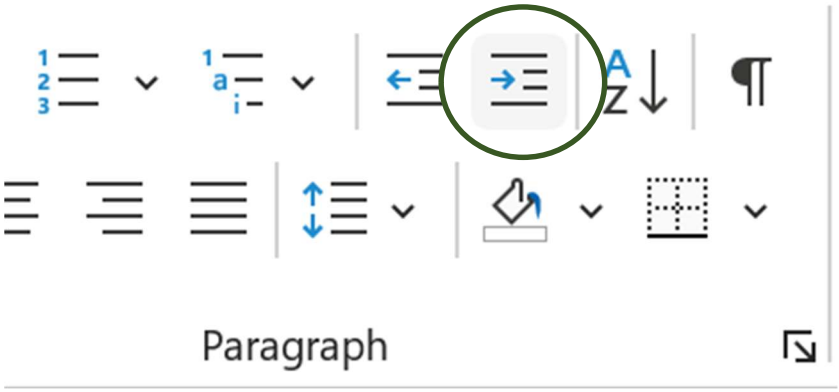
1. Click and drag to select the text you want to change the spacing of.
2. Click the **Home** tab at the top of your screen.
3. Click the **Line and Paragraph Spacing** (lines with two vertical arrows) dropdown menu in the **Paragraph** group of the Ribbon.
4. Select the line spacing of your choice.



Inserting Paragraph Indents

Use different paragraph indents to make certain aspects of your document stand out.

1. Click on the line you want to indent.
2. Click the **Home** tab at the top of your screen.
3. Click the **Increase Indent** button in the **Paragraph** group of the Ribbon.



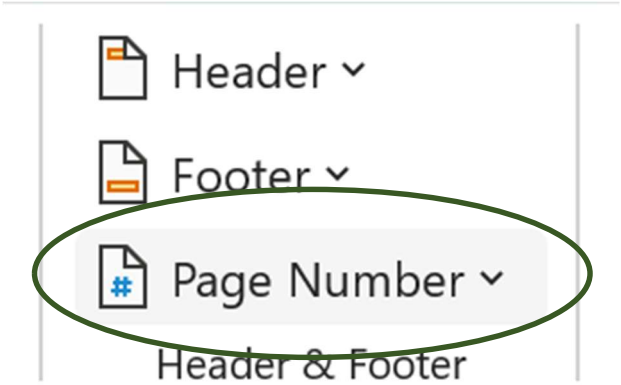
Troubleshooting tip: If you have previously used the **Tab** key to create an indent, the **Decrease Indent** button will not work; instead, use the **Backspace** key.

Inserting Page Numbers

Page numbers can be a helpful formatting choice to keep the different pages clear, and for better use finding specific sections from your table of contents.

---

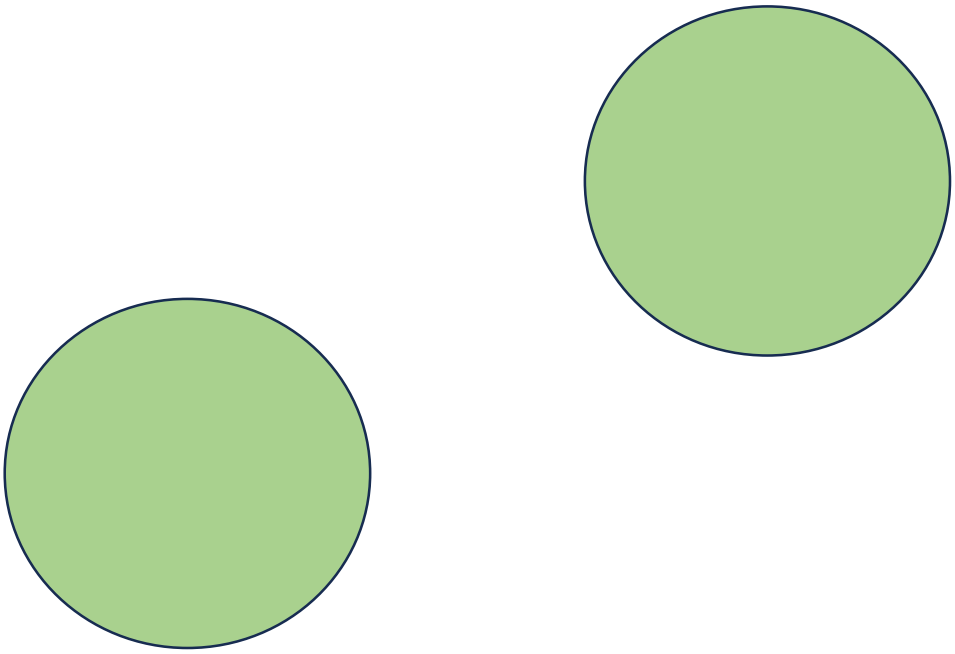
1. Click the **Insert** tab.
2. Click the **Page Number** dropdown menu in the **Header & Footer** group of the Ribbon.
3. Select the page number place where you want your page numbers to be in your document. Another menu opens.
4. Click the position of the page numbers you want.



Your page numbers are now placed in your document.

Chapter 2:

Formatting the Document

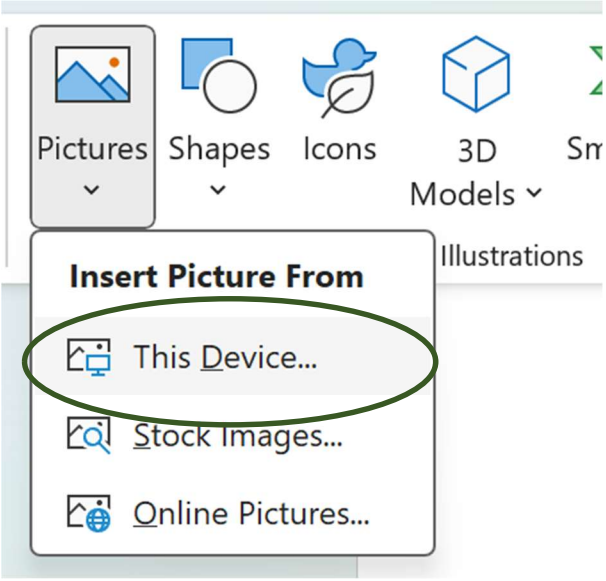


Inserting Images

Insert images from your computer into your document to support text you may be documenting.

---

1. Click the **Insert** tab.
2. Click the **Pictures** dropdown menu in the **Illustrations** group of the Ribbon.
3. Click **This Device...**. A new window appears.
4. Find the image you want to insert from your files.
5. Click **Insert** on the new window.



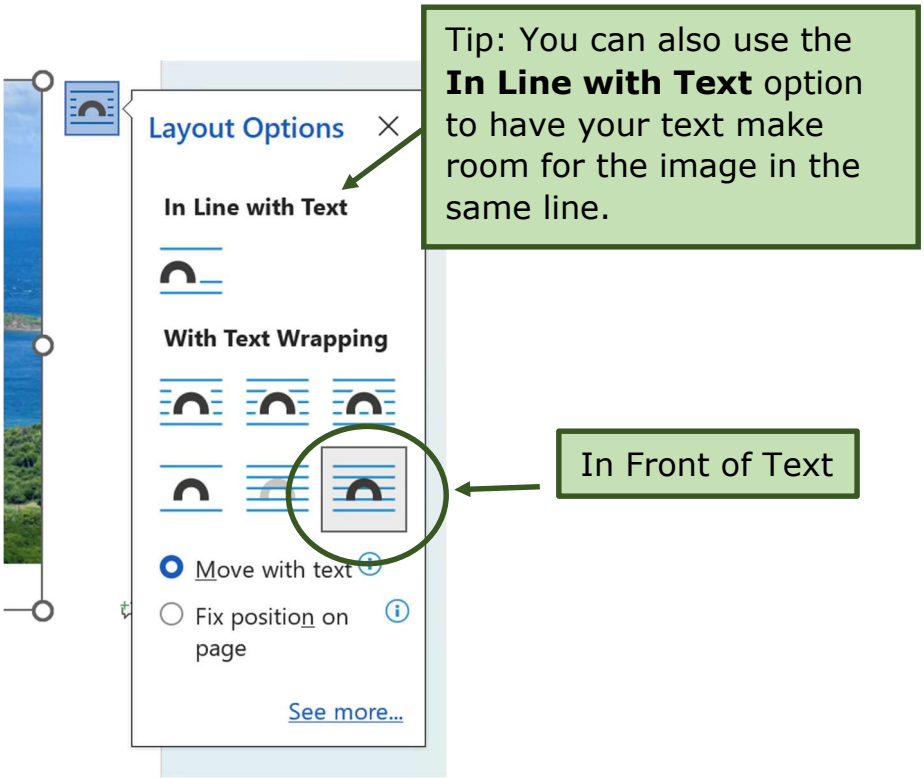
Your image is now placed in your document.

Positioning Image on the Page

You can move your image anywhere in your document without disrupting any text that is there.

---

1. Select the image you want to position by clicking it.
2. Click the **Layout Options** icon that appears to the right of your image.
3. Click **In Front of Text** under the **With Text Wrapping** option.



You can now move your image anywhere in your document.

Inserting Captions

For referencing images, figures, tables, and charts, inserting captions is a way to find objects referenced to in the text.

---

1. Select the object you want to add a caption to.
2. Click the **References** tab.
3. Click **Insert Caption** in the **Captions** group of the Ribbon.
4. Select the label that best describes your object under the **Options** section.
5. Select the position where you want your caption to appear under the **Options** section
6. Click **OK**.

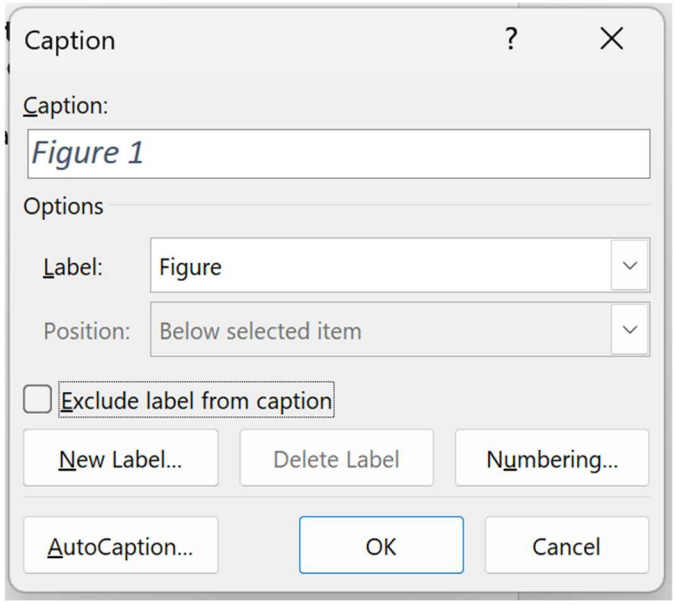


Figure 1

Tip: You can change the displayed text once clicking **OK** by using the **Backspace** key and typing in your desired text.

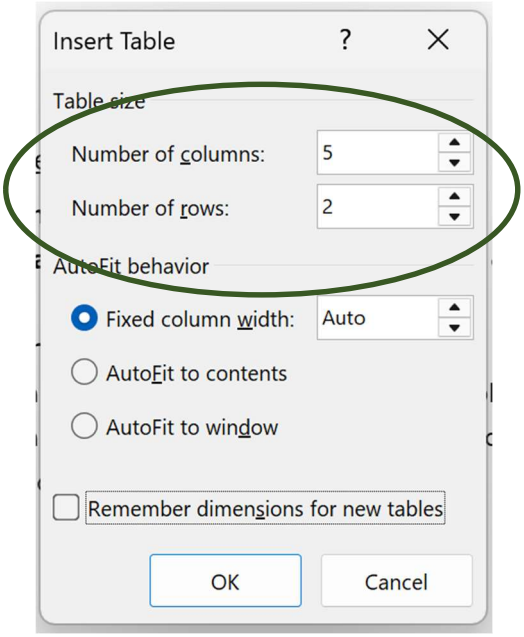
Your object now displays a caption in the chosen place.

Inserting Tables

You can use tables to display data and make your report appear organized and offer visual aid to your readers eye.

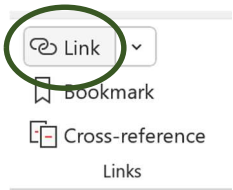
---

1. Click the **Insert** tab.
2. Click the **Table** drop down menu in the **Tables** group of the Ribbon.
3. Click **Insert Table…**. A new window opens.
4. Enter the number of columns you want your table to have.
5. Enter the number of rows you want your table to have. (You can add and delete any extra later!)
6. Click **OK**.

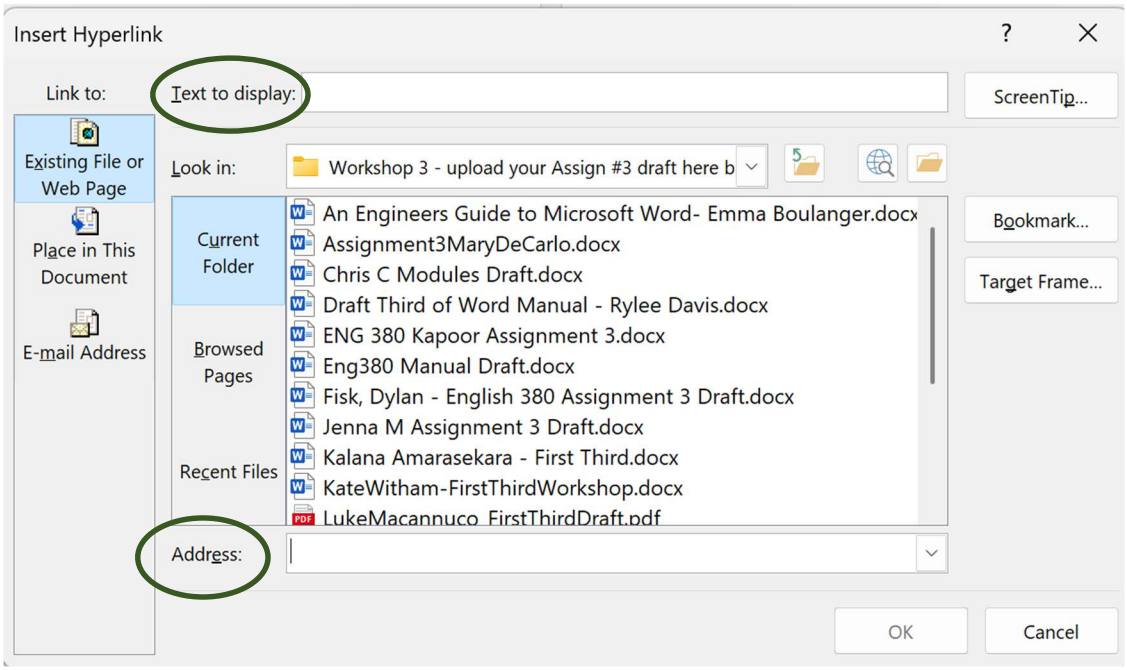


Inserting Links

You can use links to provide accessible, clickable navigation to external and internal information such as evidence in a lab report.



1. Click the **Insert** tab.
2. Click the **Link** button (not the dropdown menu!!) in the **Links** group of the Ribbon. A new window appears.
3. Type the text you want your hyperlink to appear as in the **Text to display** box.
4. Paste your hyperlink in the **Address:** box at the bottom of the window.
5. Click **OK**.

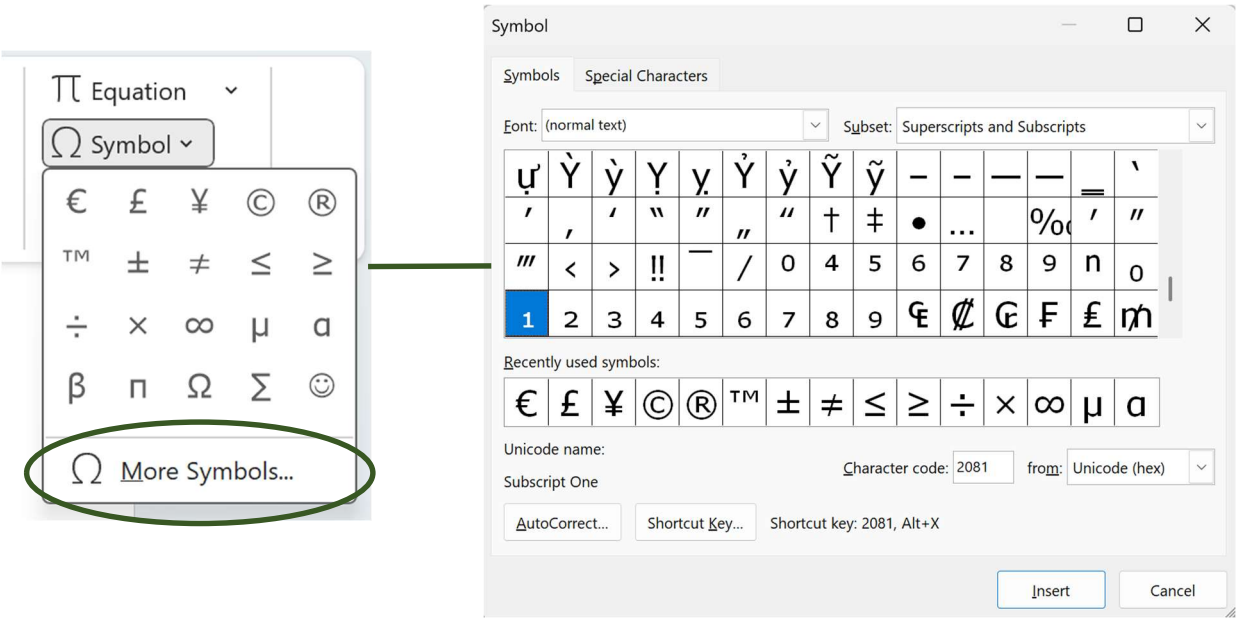


Inserting Symbols

Symbols are very useful in Word when you are trying to type out equations or special characters in your document.

---

1. Insert your cursor where you would like your symbol to be.
2. Click the **Insert** tab.
3. Click the **Symbol** dropdown menu in the **Symbol** group of the Ribbon.
4. Click the **More Symbols** option. A new window opens.
5. Search for and click on the symbol you want to insert into your document. The symbol highlights in a blue color.
6. Click **Insert**.



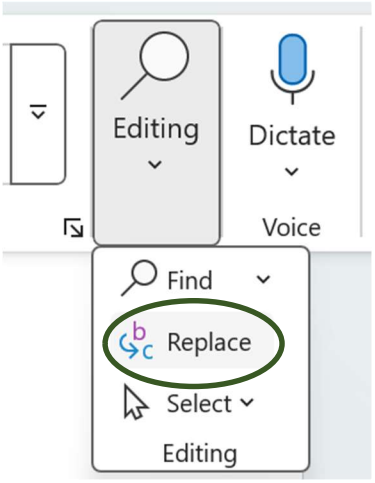
The symbol is now entered into your document.

Find and Replace

Changing one word to be another word every time it appears in your document all at once can be an efficient way of editing your document.

---

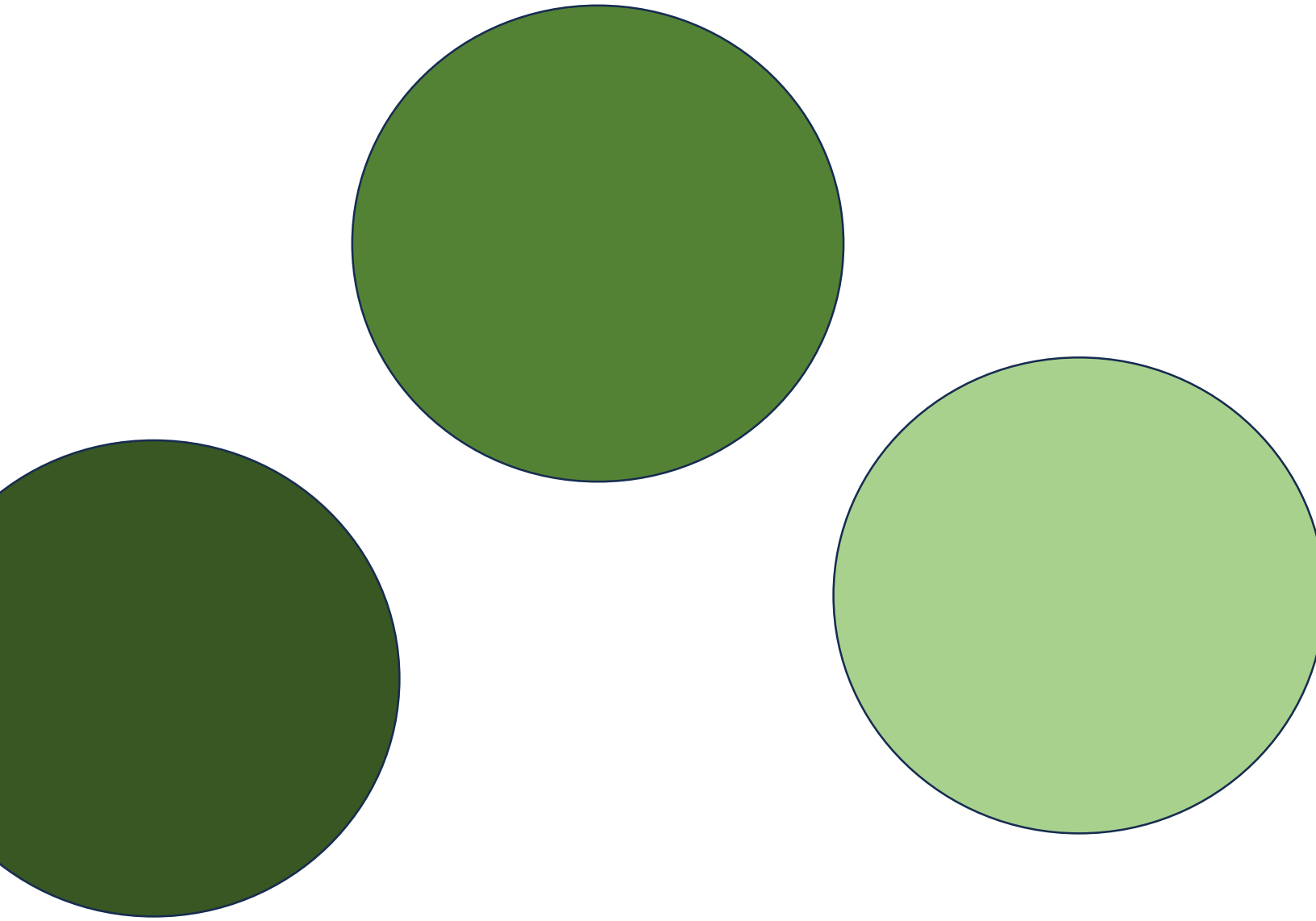
1. Click the **Home** tab.
2. Click the **Editing** dropdown menu on the Ribbon.
3. Click **Replace**. A new window opens.



4. Type the word you want to replace into the **Find what** box.
5. Type the word you want to replace your previous word with into the **Replace with** box.
6. Click **Replace All** to replace the word every time it appears in your document.

Alternatively:

7. Click **Replace** to replace just the word that is currently highlighted.
8. Click **Find Next** to skip the word that is currently highlighted and go to the next appearance.



Chapter 3:

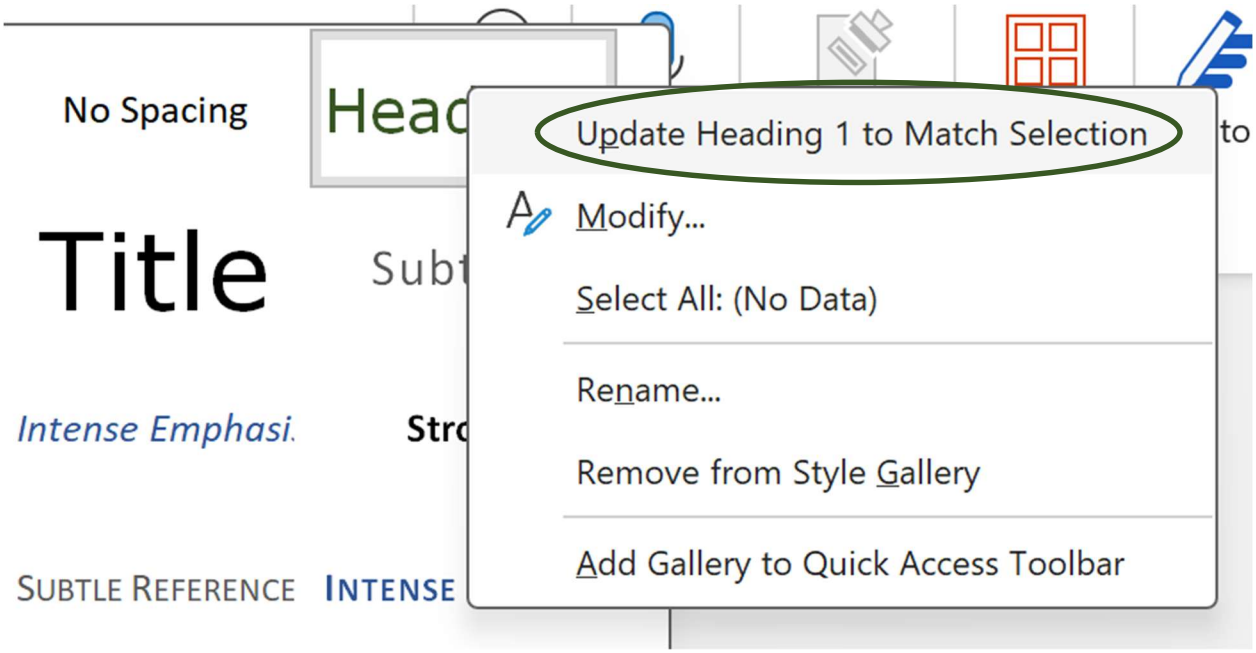
Further Formatting Techniques

How to Preset Headings Using Styles

Setting a style can help you save time when writing longer documents that may use characterizations other than the default settings.

---

1. Click on the **Home** tab.
2. Format a section of your text using the text preferences of your choice.
3. Highlight the text you changed.
4. Click on the down arrow in the **Styles** group of the Ribbon.
5. Double click **Heading 1** on your mouse pad (right click for mouse users!). A new window opens.
6. Select the **Update Heading 1 to Match Selection** option.



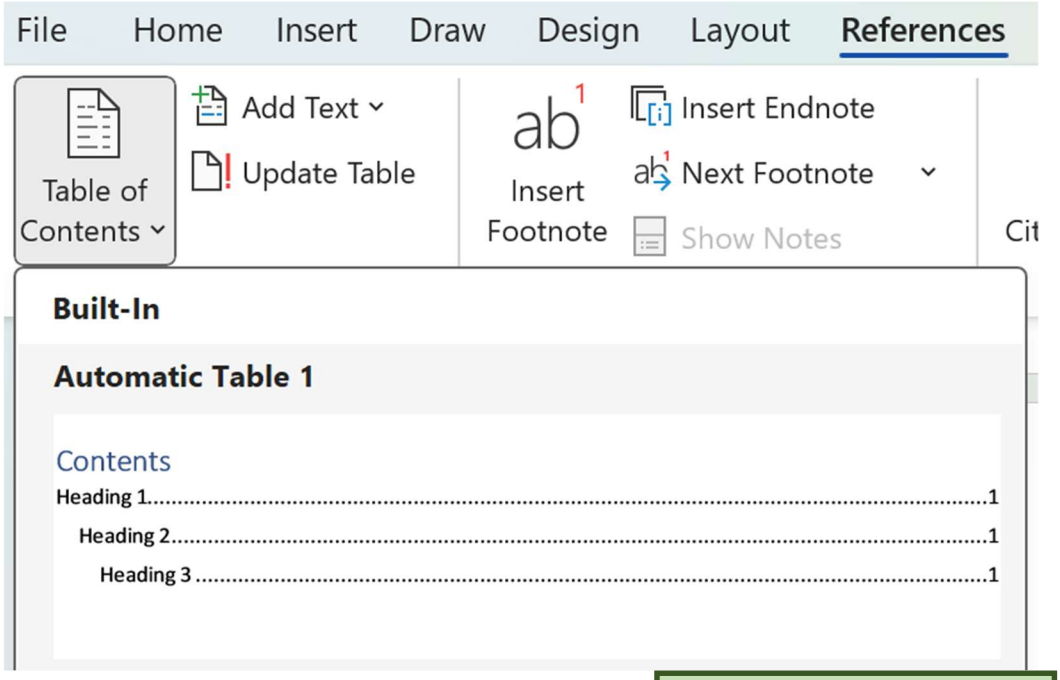
Your text will remain the same, however now whenever you highlight the text and click on that style, your text changes to reflect the style you set.

Inserting a Table of Contents

Adding a table of contents will ensure your document can be followed and allow your readers to know what is in the document.

---

1. Click on the **References** tab.
2. Click on the **Table of Contents** dropdown menu in the **Table of Contents** group of the Ribbon.
3. Select the option that best fits you (you can change this later).



Your Table of Contents is now placed in your document.

Troubleshooting tip: If there are no styles applied in your document, Word will not be able to generate a Table of Contents.

Inserting an Excel Spreadsheet

Inserting an Excel spreadsheet will allow you to work with the excel software and shortcuts within your document, eliminating the need to insert a non-editable image.

---

1. Click on the **Insert** tab.
2. Click on the **Table** dropdown menu in the **Tables** group of the Ribbon.
3. Click on **Excel Spreadsheet**.

There is now a blank, fully functional, excel spreadsheet in your document.

Chapter 4:

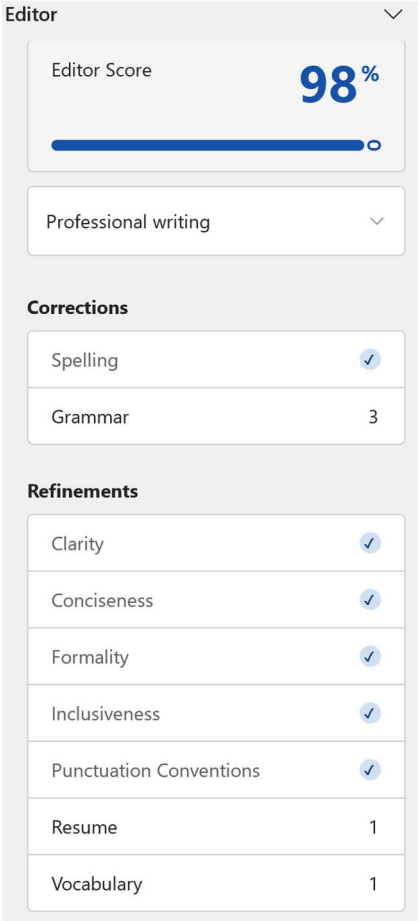
Final Steps

Using Word's Editor Function

Word's Editor function shows any grammatical, refinement errors, and the overall tone within a document, which can be useful for navigating longer documents.

---

1. Click on the **Home** tab.
2. Click on the **Editor** option on the right end of the Ribbon. A side menu opens.
3. Click on the dropdown menu below the blue **Editor Score** box.
4. Select the writing option that best fits your paper.
5. Go through the options with numbers next to them under **Corrections** and **Refinements** to edit your document.



Saving Your Document

Saving your documents ensures all elements are fixed and all format stays the same when sharing or submitting a document.

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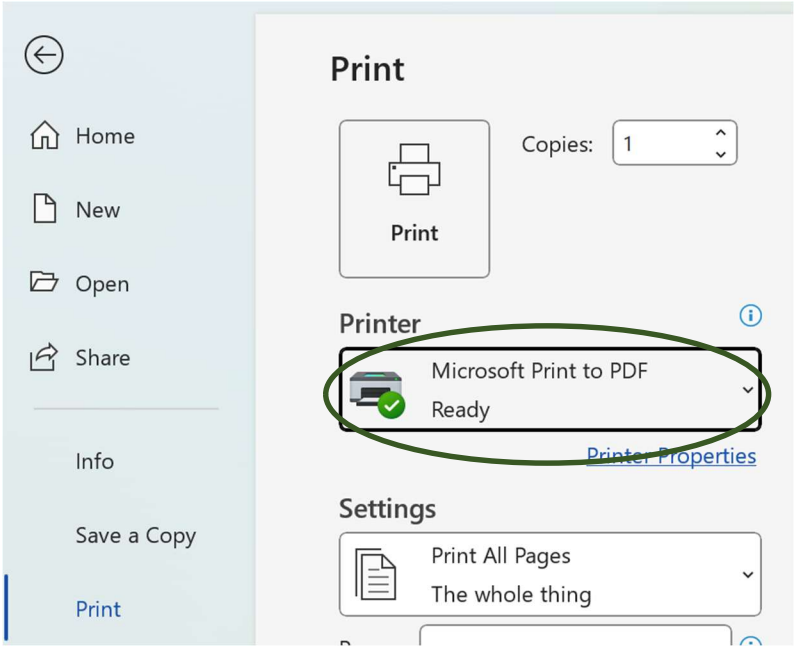
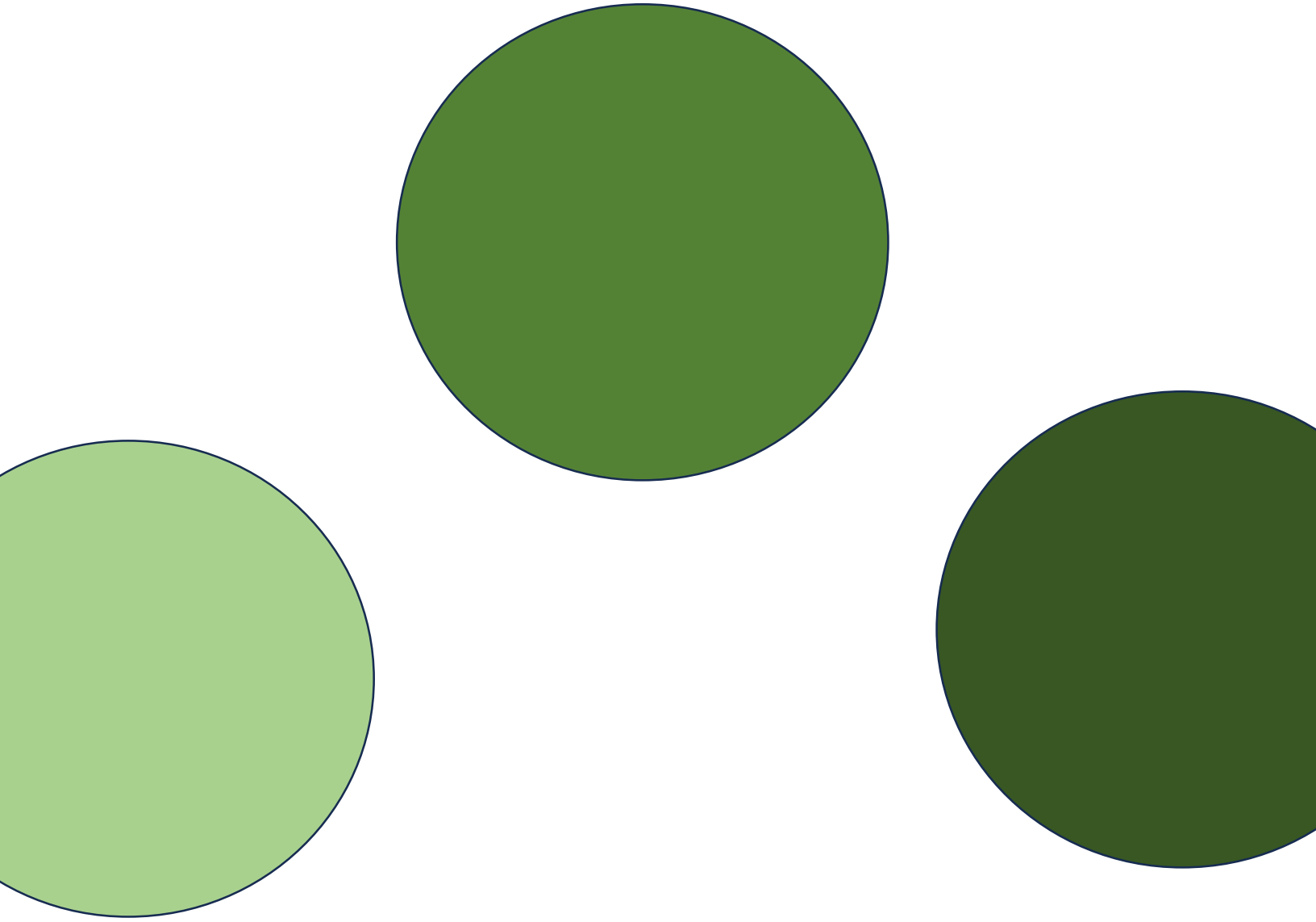
1. Click on the **File** tab. You are taken to a new window.
2. Click **Print** on the side menu.
3. Click the **Printer** dropdown menu.
4. Ensure that **Microsoft Print to PDF** is selected.
5. Click **Print**. A new window opens.



6. Name your file something resembling the content and your name.
7. Select the place you want your file to appear on your desktop.

Your document is now saved as a pdf on your computer.



Colophon

An Engineer’s Guide to Microsoft Word was designed, printed and bound by Emma Boulanger in the fall of 2025. With one copy printed worldwide, this manual was set in Verdana in Microsoft Word with a page size of 8 ½” by 11”.

Acknowledgements

Special thanks to Janine Solberg for reviewing and giving feedback, helping me through the creation of this Word manual. Thank you to Carter Whitney for providing me with the user research I needed. Thanks to John Emerson for reading specific modules for clarity, double checking my instruction; a greatly needed effort. And finally, thank you to the students of English 380 for peer reviewing my manual, giving me feedback and points to work on. All your help was appreciated during the creation of this Microsoft Word Manual.